

MODULE 40 / 40

American Kestrel

*Falco sparverius***QUICK STATS**

Length	8.7 – 12.2 in (22 – 31 cm)
Wingspan	20.1 – 24.0 in (51 – 61 cm)
Weight	2.8 – 5.8 oz (80 – 165 g)
Lifespan	Up to 17 years (avg. 3–5 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The American Kestrel is the smallest and most colorful falcon in North America — a jewel-like bird of open country whose exquisite plumage and spirited hovering flight make it one of the most charismatic raptors on the continent. The male is unmistakable: a blue-gray wing against a rufous-chestnut back, a spotted buff breast, and two bold black "sideburn" marks on a white-cheeked face create a pattern unlike any other North American bird. Despite being a raptor, it is robin-sized, and its habit of perching on telephone wires along roadsides makes it one of the most commonly observed hawks in North America — a familiar sight to travelers across the continent.

HABITAT & RANGE

The American Kestrel is a year-round resident across most of North America, breeding from Alaska and Canada south through the entire United States, Mexico, and Central America, and into South America. Northern populations migrate south in winter. It inhabits open and semi-open habitats: farmland, roadsides, grasslands, desert edges, suburban areas, and any open land with perch sites and prey. It is cavity-nesting and readily accepts nest boxes, making it one of the most successfully managed raptor species.

DIET & FEEDING

- Grasshoppers and large insects — the primary summer food
- Mice, voles, and shrews — dominant prey in winter
- Small birds taken occasionally, especially in winter
- Lizards, small snakes, and frogs in warm climates
- Earthworms and beetles gleaned from open ground
- Hovers 20–30 feet above the ground to spot prey below

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

The American Kestrel is renowned for its hovering ability — it can hang nearly motionless in the air, facing into the wind, scanning the ground below with extraordinary visual acuity. Kestrels can see ultraviolet light, which allows them to detect the urine trails of voles — invisible to humans — leading directly to prey burrows. They are aggressive hunters despite their small size, taking prey as large as themselves. Outside the breeding season they are largely solitary and territorial. In winter, females tend to remain farther north than males.

NESTING & BREEDING

American Kestrels are obligate cavity nesters — they cannot excavate their own holes and depend entirely on existing cavities: natural tree hollows, old woodpecker holes, cliff crevices, and nest boxes. No nesting material is added. Clutches of 4–5 white to pale pink eggs with brown spotting are incubated by both parents for 29–31 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 28–31 days. One brood per season. Nest box programs have successfully reversed local population declines.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The American Kestrel's call is a rapid, high-pitched "klee-klee-klee" or "killy-killy-killy" — a sharp, excited series that carries well across open farmland. It is frequently given in flight and when alarmed near the nest. Males give a softer "whining" call during courtship. The call is one of the most distinctive raptor vocalizations in North America and immediately announces the bird's presence even before it is seen.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The American Kestrel population has declined by approximately 47% since 1966 — one of the steepest declines of any North American raptor. Loss of open farmland and grassland habitat, reduction in large insects from pesticide use, competition with European Starlings for nest cavities, and secondary poisoning from rodenticides are the primary drivers. Nest box programs along roadsides and field edges have demonstrated significant success in reversing local declines.

FEEDER TIPS

- Kestrels do not visit bird feeders — open habitat and nest boxes are the key
- Install a kestrel nest box on a pole 10–30 feet high at the edge of open land
- Entrance hole should be 3 inches in diameter; box interior 9 x 9 x 12 inches
- Maintain open grassland or meadow nearby — essential foraging habitat
- Avoid rodenticides — poisoned prey causes secondary poisoning in kestrels

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back (male)	Rufous-chestnut with black barring
Wings (male)	Blue-gray — striking contrast with back
Head	Blue-gray crown, white cheek, two black sideburns
Breast & belly	Pale buff with dark spots
Tail (male)	Rufous with black subterminal band
Female — wings	Rufous-brown, heavily barred

COLOR ME!

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